CORE FALSE BELIEF #17 · RULES I LIVE BY

"I must be perfect."

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Perfectionism often grows in homes where love or approval seemed to depend on performance, where mistakes were criticized harshly, or where a child tried to keep chaos at bay by being "good." Schools, sports, workplaces, and even churches can reward it. Perfectionism can look like high standards, but underneath is often fear of failure, rejection, or shame.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture teaches that all have sinned and fall short, and that we are made right with God freely by His grace, not by being flawless. The Lord has compassion on His children, because He knows how we are formed and remembers that we are dust. Paul was confident that God, who began a good work in believers, will complete it. Doing our best is good; demanding perfection of ourselves is a burden God never placed on us. Jesus invites us to take His yoke, which is easy and light.

> *"As a father has compassion on his children, so the LORD has compassion on those who fear Him. For He knows our frame; He is mindful that we are dust"* (Psalm 103:13–14).

Also see

> "For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God, and are justified freely by His grace through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus" (Romans 3:23–24).

> "Being confident of this, that He who began a good work in you will carry it on to completion until the day of Christ Jesus" (Philippians 1:6).

> "But He said to me, 'My grace is sufficient for you, for My power is perfected in weakness.' Therefore I will boast all the more gladly in my weaknesses, so that the power of Christ may rest on me" (2 Corinthians 12:9).

> "Come to Me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest. Take My yoke upon you and learn from Me; for I am gentle and humble in heart, and you will find rest for your souls. For My yoke is easy and My burden is light" (Matthew 11:28–30).

Common self-statements

- If it isn't perfect, it's a failure.
- I can't let anyone see my flaws.
- I have to do it all myself so it's done right.
- Good enough isn't good enough.
- If I make a mistake, people will think less of me.
- I should be able to do better.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Seeing anything less than perfect as total failure.
- Should statements: Living by rigid rules about how I must perform.
- Discounting the positive: Overlooking what I did well because of one flaw.
- Mind reading: Assuming others judge me harshly for small mistakes.

Challenging questions

- Who taught me that I had to be perfect?
- What am I afraid will happen if I am not perfect?
- Do I hold others to the same standard I hold myself?
- What does God expect of me, and what does His grace provide?
- What has perfectionism cost me?
- What would "good enough" look like in one area this week?

Truth summary

> I want to do things well, and that is good. But I am human, and God knows I am made of dust. He accepts me by grace, not by flawless performance. I can do my best, make mistakes, and rest in His grace.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Grace
- Thinking, Unhealthy
- Humility
- Tired
- Self-Esteem, Low

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Thinking, Healthy
- Self-Esteem, Low

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Grace Wins — Matthew West
Grace offers a new beginning rather than defining a person by failure.

Truth Be Told — Matthew West featuring Carly Pearce
Honesty about struggles makes room for grace and support instead of pretending to be fine.

Broken Things — Matthew West
God can work through imperfect people without waiting for them to become flawless.

Amazing Grace — Reawaken Hymns
This classic hymn locates salvation and sustaining hope in grace rather than merit.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I must be perfect"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I must be perfect." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who taught me I had to be perfect?
- ☐ What am I afraid will happen if I'm not?
- ☐ Do I hold others to the same standard?
- ☐ What does God's grace provide?
- ☐ What has perfectionism cost me?
- ☐ What would good enough look like?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ God knows I am dust and has compassion on me.
- ☐ I am made right by grace, not perfection.
- ☐ God will finish the work He started in me.
- ☐ Good enough is often good enough.
- ☐ Mistakes are part of being human.
- ☐ Jesus' yoke is easy and light.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Psalm 103:13–14**
  "As a father has compassion on his children, so the LORD has compassion on those who fear Him. For He knows our frame; He is mindful that we are dust."
- ☐ **Romans 3:23–24**
  "For all have sinned and fall short of the glory of God, and are justified freely by His grace through the redemption that is in Christ Jesus."
- ☐ **Philippians 1:6**
  "Being confident of this, that He who began a good work in you will carry it on to completion until the day of Christ Jesus."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ Good enough today: Each day, write one thing you allowed to be "good enough" and what happened as a result.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Psalm 103:13–14 becomes: "Linda can write: "God knows how I am made. He has compassion on me when I fall short.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Grace" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If this belief comes with hopelessness or thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. You do not have to carry this alone.

- ☐ Do something imperfectly on purpose. Choose one low-stakes task, such as sending an email without rereading it three times, and let it be good enough.
- ☐ Count the cost. Write what perfectionism has cost you in time, rest, relationships, or joy.
- ☐ Share a flaw. Tell one trusted person about a mistake you made this week. Notice how they respond.
- ☐ Set a time limit. Give a task a set amount of time, and stop when the time is up.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I must be perfect": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Something I let be good enough
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I must be perfect.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, I have tried so hard to be perfect, and I am tired. Thank You that You know I am dust and that Your grace covers me. Help me do my best, accept my limits, and rest in Your love. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

CORE FALSE BELIEF #18 · RULES I LIVE BY

“I must have everyone’s approval.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

The need for approval often begins with parents whose love seemed conditional, frequent criticism, or rejection by peers. A child who learns that keeping others happy keeps them safe may grow into an adult who can’t say no, avoids conflict, and feels crushed by any disapproval. Social media can intensify the hunger for likes and praise.

What Scripture teaches

Paul asked whether he was seeking the approval of people or of God, and concluded that pleasing people could not be his goal. Proverbs warns that the fear of man is a snare, but trusting the Lord brings security. Scripture calls us to work wholeheartedly for the Lord rather than for people. God already approves of His children in Christ. That approval frees us to love and serve others without needing their applause, and to accept that not everyone will be pleased with us.

> *“Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God? Or am I striving to please men? If I were still trying to please men, I would not be a servant of Christ”* (Galatians 1:10).

Also see

> “The fear of man is a snare, but whoever trusts in the LORD is set securely on high” (Proverbs 29:25).

> “Whatever you do, work at it with your whole being, for the Lord and not for men” (Colossians 3:23).

> “Instead, we speak as those approved by God to be entrusted with the gospel, not in order to please men but God, who examines our hearts” (1 Thessalonians 2:4).

> “The LORD is on my side; I will not be afraid. What can man do to me?” (Psalm 118:6).

Common self-statements

- If someone is upset with me, I’ve failed.
- I can’t say no.
- I need people to like me.
- I worry constantly about what others think.
- Criticism crushes me.
- I’ll go along to keep the peace.

Common logical errors

- Mind reading: Assuming people disapprove of me.
- Catastrophizing: Treating someone’s disapproval as a disaster.
- Personalization: Taking others’ moods as a judgment on me.
- Should statements: Believing I should please everyone.

Challenging questions

- Whose approval did I need most growing up?
- Is it possible for anyone to please everyone?
- What am I afraid will happen if someone disapproves?

- Whose approval matters most, and do I already have it?
- What have I given up to keep others happy?
- Where could I be honest even if someone is not pleased?

Truth summary

> I care what people think, and that is human. But I cannot please everyone, and I don't need to. God already accepts me in Christ. His approval frees me to be honest, say no when I need to, and love others without needing their applause.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Fear
- Humility
- Love, By God
- Communication

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Self-Esteem, Low
- Communication

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Greater — MercyMe
God's presence and grace challenge shame and the need to win everyone's approval.

You Say — Lauren Daigle
God's loving assessment challenges identity based only on weakness or feelings.

Voice of Truth — Casting Crowns
Test accusing or frightening messages against God's truth.

Blessed Assurance — Larry Ford and Lillie Knauls with Gaither
This classic hymn celebrates belonging to Christ and resting in His salvation.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I must have everyone's approval"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I must have everyone's approval." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Whose approval did I need growing up?
- ☐ Can anyone please everyone?
- ☐ What am I afraid will happen if someone disapproves?
- ☐ Whose approval matters most?
- ☐ What have I given up to please others?
- ☐ Where could I be honest?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I live for God's approval, not man's.
- ☐ The fear of man is a snare.
- ☐ God already accepts me in Christ.
- ☐ No one can please everyone.
- ☐ Disapproval is uncomfortable, not dangerous.
- ☐ I can say no and still be kind.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Galatians 1:10**
  "Am I now seeking the approval of men, or of God? Or am I striving to please men? If I were still trying to please men, I would not be a servant of Christ."
- ☐ **Proverbs 29:25**
  "The fear of man is a snare, but whoever trusts in the LORD is set securely on high."
- ☐ **Colossians 3:23**
  "Whatever you do, work at it with your whole being, for the Lord and not for men."

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] When I sought approval: Each day, write one time you did something mainly for approval, and one time you acted on your own convictions.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Galatians 1:10 becomes: "Mark can write: "I'm not living to please people. I already have God's approval in Christ.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Self-Esteem, Low" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If this belief comes with hopelessness or thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. You do not have to carry this alone.

- [ ] Say one kind no. Decline one request this week that you would normally accept to avoid disapproval.
- [ ] Share an honest opinion. Express a different opinion respectfully in a safe setting.
- [ ] Notice the people-pleasing. Each time you change your behavior to win approval, ask, "Whose approval am I seeking?"
- [ ] Rest in God's approval. Read Galatians 1:10 each morning and remind yourself that God already accepts you in Christ.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie “I must have everyone’s approval”: _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A time I acted on my convictions
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I must have everyone’s approval.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD’S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I have spent so much energy trying to please everyone. Thank You that I already have Your approval in Christ. Free me from the fear of man, and help me live honestly and lovingly for You. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

CORE FALSE BELIEF #19 · RULES I LIVE BY

“I must be in control.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

The need for control often grows in chaotic or frightening homes, where a child tried to bring order by managing everything around them. It can also follow trauma, a sudden loss, or a time when things spun out of control. Control can feel like safety. But because so much in life is beyond our control, this belief often leads to anxiety, tension in relationships, and exhaustion.

What Scripture teaches

Scripture teaches that we can make plans, but the Lord directs our steps. James warns against confident boasting about tomorrow and teaches us to say, “If the Lord is willing.” God tells us to be still and know that He is God. Trusting the Lord with all our heart rather than leaning on our own understanding is not passivity; it is placing control in better hands. We are responsible for our choices, but the outcome belongs to God.

> *“A man’s heart plans his course, but the LORD determines his steps”* (Proverbs 16:9).

Also see

> “Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and lean not on your own understanding; in all your ways acknowledge Him, and He will make your paths straight” (Proverbs 3:5–6).

> “‘Be still and know that I am God; I will be exalted among the nations, I will be exalted over the earth.’” (Psalm 46:10).

> “Come now, you who say, ‘Today or tomorrow we will go to this or that city, spend a year there, carry on business, and make a profit.’ You do not even know what will happen tomorrow! What is your life? You are a mist that appears for a little while and then vanishes. Instead, you ought to say, ‘If the Lord is willing, we will live and do this or that.’” (James 4:13–15).

> “Who of you by worrying can add a single hour to his life?” (Matthew 6:27).

Common self-statements

- If I don’t handle it, it will fall apart.
- I can’t stand not knowing what will happen.
- Others won’t do it right.
- I have to plan for every possibility.
- Letting go feels dangerous.
- If I lose control, something bad will happen.

Common logical errors

- Catastrophizing: Believing disaster will follow if I loosen my grip.
- Should statements: Insisting things must go my way.
- Fortune telling: Predicting that others will fail if I don’t manage them.
- Overestimating control: Thinking I can prevent outcomes that are really in God’s hands.

Challenging questions

- When did I learn that I had to be in control?
- What am I actually able to control, and what not?
- What does my need for control cost me and others?
- What happens when I try to control things I cannot?
- What does God say about who directs my steps?
- What is one thing I could release to God this week?

Truth summary

> I am responsible for my own choices, and I can plan wisely. But I cannot control everything, and I don't have to. God directs my steps and holds what I cannot. I can do my part and trust Him with the rest.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Trust
- Plans
- Will of God
- Anxiety/Worry
- Peace

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Anxiety/Worry/Fear
- Prayer

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

What You Want — Tenth Avenue North
Following God involves trust and surrender without needing control of every outcome.

Just Be Held — Casting Crowns
God's care remains when control, strength, or explanations run out.

Already There — Casting Crowns
God's perspective extends beyond what we can currently understand.

Turn Your Eyes Upon Jesus — Reawaken Hymns
This classic hymn directs attention to Christ when fear or earthly concerns dominate.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I must be in control"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I must be in control." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ When did I learn I had to be in control?
- ☐ What can I control and what not?
- ☐ What does control cost me?
- ☐ What happens when I try to control the uncontrollable?
- ☐ Who directs my steps?
- ☐ What can I release this week?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I plan, and the Lord directs my steps.
- ☐ I can be still and know He is God.
- ☐ I am responsible for my choices, not every outcome.
- ☐ Letting go is trusting, not giving up.
- ☐ God holds what I cannot.
- ☐ Worry cannot add an hour to my life.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ **Proverbs 16:9**
  "A man's heart plans his course, but the LORD determines his steps."
- ☐ **Proverbs 3:5–6**
  "Trust in the LORD with all your heart, and lean not on your own understanding; in all your ways acknowledge Him, and He will make your paths straight."
- ☐ **Psalm 46:10**
  "'Be still and know that I am God; I will be exalted among the nations, I will be exalted over the earth.'"

A verse I found myself: _____

_____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- ☐ Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- ☐ Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- ☐ Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- ☐ Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- ☐ What I released today: Each day, write one thing you tried to control and one thing you chose to release to God.
- ☐ My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Proverbs 16:9 becomes: "Maria can write: "I can make my plans, but the Lord directs my steps. I can trust Him with the outcome.""
- ☐ Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- ☐ Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- ☐ Reading: The "Trust" topic in Pearls.
- ☐ Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If this belief comes with hopelessness or thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. You do not have to carry this alone.

- ☐ Draw the circle. Draw a circle. Inside, write what you can control. Outside, write what you can't. Pray over the outside list.
- ☐ Delegate one task. Let someone else do one task their way this week without correcting them.
- ☐ Practice uncertainty. Make one small plan with an open end, such as trying a new restaurant without reading reviews.
- ☐ Pray a release prayer. Each morning, name one worry and say, "Lord, I give this to You."

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie “I must be in control”: _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	Something I released
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I must be in control.~~

THE TRUTH

_____

_____

GOD'S WORD

_____

_____

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I hold on so tightly because I am afraid. Thank You that You direct my steps and hold what I cannot. Help me do my part, release the rest, and rest in Your care. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.

CORE FALSE BELIEF #20 · RULES I LIVE BY

“I must not make mistakes.”

✦ ✦ ✦

Where it often comes from

Fear of mistakes often comes from harsh punishment, ridicule, or anger when we got something wrong as children. Some families or schools treated every error as a character flaw. Later, a person may avoid trying new things, procrastinate, redo work endlessly, or hide errors, all to avoid the shame that once came with mistakes.

What Scripture teaches

James writes plainly that we all stumble in many ways. Scripture never pretends God’s people are error-free; it shows Him forgiving, teaching, and restoring them. When we sin, confession brings forgiveness and cleansing. When we simply make honest mistakes, God’s mercies are new every morning. The righteous fall and rise again. In Christ there is no condemnation. Mistakes are part of learning, not proof of failure, and God is patient with us as we grow.

> *“We all stumble in many ways. If anyone is never at fault in what he says, he is a perfect man, able to control his whole body”* (James 3:2).

Also see

> “If we confess our sins, He is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness” (1 John 1:9).

> “For though a righteous man may fall seven times, he still gets up; but the wicked stumble in bad times” (Proverbs 24:16).

> “Because of the loving devotion of the LORD we are not consumed, for His mercies never fail. They are new every morning; great is Your faithfulness!” (Lamentations 3:22–23).

> “Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus” (Romans 8:1).

Common self-statements

- Mistakes are unacceptable.
- If I make a mistake, I’ll be humiliated.
- I’d rather not try than get it wrong.
- I go over things again and again to be sure.
- One error can ruin everything.
- I can’t forgive myself for mistakes.

Common logical errors

- All-or-nothing thinking: Treating one mistake as total failure.
- Catastrophizing: Imagining terrible consequences from small errors.
- Labeling: Calling myself stupid or useless after a mistake.
- Should statements: Insisting I should never get anything wrong.

Challenging questions

- Who taught me that mistakes were unacceptable?
- What actually happened the last time I made a mistake?

- How do I treat other people when they make mistakes?
- What have I learned from past mistakes?
- What does God do with our mistakes and sins?
- What would I try if I weren't afraid of mistakes?

Truth summary

> I will make mistakes, because every person does. Mistakes are part of learning, not proof that I am a failure. God forgives my sins, is patient with my errors, and helps me grow. I can try, learn, and keep going.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

- Forgiveness
- Grace
- Confession
- Thinking, Healthy
- Humility

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Forgive/Forgiveness
- Thinking, Healthy

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

> Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

Grace Wins — Matthew West
Grace offers a new beginning rather than defining a person by failure.

Dear Younger Me — MercyMe
Past wounds and choices do not have to become a person's permanent identity.

East to West — Casting Crowns
God's forgiveness addresses lingering guilt and fear of condemnation.

He Touched Me — Gaither Vocal Band
This older favorite celebrates Christ's restoring grace; it is not a promise of immediate physical healing.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, how would I think, speak, and act today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I must not make mistakes"

✦ ✦ ✦

Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I must not make mistakes." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ Who taught me mistakes were unacceptable?
- ☐ What happened the last time I made a mistake?
- ☐ How do I treat others' mistakes?
- ☐ What have I learned from mistakes?
- ☐ What does God do with mistakes and sins?
- ☐ What would I try if I weren't afraid?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ We all stumble in many ways.
- ☐ God forgives and cleanses me.
- ☐ Mistakes are part of learning.
- ☐ There is no condemnation in Christ.
- ☐ His mercies are new every morning.
- ☐ I can try without fear.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ James 3:2
  "We all stumble in many ways. If anyone is never at fault in what he says, he is a perfect man, able to control his whole body."
- ☐ 1 John 1:9
  "If we confess our sins, He is faithful and just to forgive us our sins and to cleanse us from all unrighteousness."
- ☐ Romans 8:1
  "Therefore, there is now no condemnation for those who are in Christ Jesus."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

✦ ✦ ✦

5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] Mistakes and lessons: Each day, write one mistake you made and one thing you learned from it.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, James 3:2 becomes: "Tom can write: "Everyone stumbles, including me. God is patient with me as I learn.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Grace" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If this belief comes with hopelessness or thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. You do not have to carry this alone.

- [ ] Make a harmless mistake on purpose. Do something small imperfectly, such as mispronouncing a word or leaving a typo, and notice that nothing terrible happens.
- [ ] Try something new. Attempt one new activity where you are a beginner.
- [ ] Share a mistake. Tell one trusted person about a mistake and how you handled it.
- [ ] Respond like a coach. After a mistake, write what a kind coach would say to you.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I must not make mistakes": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A mistake I learned from
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I must not make mistakes.~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Father, I am so afraid of getting things wrong. Thank You that You know we all stumble, and that You forgive and restore. Help me try, learn, and grow without fear, resting in Your patience and grace. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.